

THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

BOOK 3 OF 12

# The Quiet House

FATHER LUCAS · AUGSBURG

DEDICATION

*For the one who is awake at three o’clock, and for the house that has grown too quiet.*



*Father Lucas*



## BOOK 3

**This book:** Night, sleep, fear, and loneliness: that the house may be at peace again.

## HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

1. **The verse.** Read it slowly, out loud if you can.
2. **The word.** A short reading, about one minute.
3. **The prayer.** Say it as written, or in your own words.
4. **Today.** One small thing to do, a question to answer on the lines, and a box to tick when it's done.

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*If you miss a morning, don't catch up.*
*Turn to today's page and begin again.*
*Keep a pen beside this book and write in it.*
*These pages are yours.*

*The Year of Untied Knots · Days 62 to 91 · Book 3 of 12*

**The knot:** Peace

**Month motto:** The house grows quiet.

## A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

*Dear friend,*

You've walked sixty-one mornings with me, and now I want to tell you where we're going. This month we go into the night. Not to fix it. Nobody fixes the night. We go in with a lamp and a good companion, and we learn where the furniture is.

Many of you sleep badly. Some of you sleep beside an empty pillow. Some wake at three with a fear that has no name, and a phone that stays quiet. I know these hours. I have kept them myself.

Thirty mornings from now, I hope your house is a little quieter. Not silent. Quiet, the way a kitchen is when someone has just said grace.

*Father Lucas*

## THE MAP OF THE MONTH

**Week 1 (Days 62–68):** The hour you wake. Lay the day down, open your hands, and learn what to do at three o'clock.

**Week 2 (Days 69–76):** Mary keeps watch. Tea, goodnight, worry, the radio off, a window, and rest as prayer.

**Week 3 (Days 77–84):** The lonely hours. The neighbor, counted blessings, the turned clock, one breath, the big bed, tomorrow.

**Week 4 (Days 85–91):** Letters, pillow prayers, rain, a lullaby, and dawn. The month ends with the quiet candle.

BOOK 3

## THREE PROMISES FOR THE MONTH

I. *I will lay the day down before I lie down.*

II. *I will say one kind word to this house each night.*

III. *I will reach first, even when the phone is quiet.*

IV. --

**Psalm of the month:** 121 — "He who keeps you will not slumber."

MY NAME



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WEEK 1

# The hour you wake

DAYS 62 TO 68

*Lay the day down, open your hands, and learn what to do at three o'clock.*

62

DAY 62

# The Hour You Wake

*My eyes stay open through the night watches, that I might meditate on your word.*

PSALM 119:148 (WEB)

Good morning, my friend. Or is it still night? Some of you opened this book in the dark, because sleep let go of you at that hour and wouldn't take you back. The house is quiet and your mind is not.

Here's what I learned the slow way. That hour isn't your enemy. It's a door that opens at the wrong time. And Mary doesn't sleep, so she's already standing on the other side of it.

This month we'll learn what to do when you wake, one small thing at a time. For now, don't fix anything. Let the dark be dark.

*Mary, it's that hour again. My eyes are open and my mind is already running ahead of me. I won't fight the dark today. I'm handing it to you, like a heavy bag at the door. Sit on the edge of my bed. Be the one who's awake, so I don't have to be. Show me what to do with this hour. Amen.*



TODAY

Before you get up, breathe out the word "Mary" ten times, slowly, with your hands open on the blanket. Count the breaths on your fingers.

☐ DONE

*What's the first thought waiting for me when I wake?*

PSALM

119 — "my eyes stay open through the night watches"; the psalm for the hour you wake. (Changed from 10: the suggested verses are about enemies, not about a bed in the dark.)

63

DAY 63

# Lay Your Day Down

*When you lie down, you will not be afraid. Yes, you will lie down, and your sleep will be sweet.*

PROVERBS 3:24 (WEB)

You carried the whole day again. The calls, the dishes, the thing you said at the pharmacy counter that you wish you'd said better. You carry it right up to the pillow, and then you wonder why sleep won't come.

Nobody told you the day is finished the moment the sun goes down. It did what it did, and you can't add one more minute to it. So set it down the way you set down grocery bags: one at a time, on the counter where it belongs.

Mary keeps a shelf for it. Tonight, when the lamp goes out, put the day there.

*Lord Jesus, here's my day. The things I did, the things I left undone, the words I wish I could take back. I'm setting them down at the foot of this bed. I'm not carrying them in with me. Mary, keep them till morning. Let my hands go empty and my breathing slow. I did what I could. Amen.*



TODAY

Tonight, before you turn off the lamp, say out loud three things you got done today. Then add, "That's enough for one day."

☐ DONE

*What am I still carrying that the day is already finished with?*

PSALM

4 — "in peace I will both lay myself down and sleep"; the best psalm for a day set down. (Changed from 11.)

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

One night of laying the day down helps. A week of it changes the room. Skip it, and the old weight finds your pillow again. Three minutes keeps it where you put it.

64

DAY 64

# Before the Light Goes Off

*I laid myself down and slept. I awakened, for the LORD sustains me.*

PSALM 3:5 (WEB)

The lamp switch is the last thing you touch. Your hand is on it, and your mind starts reading you the list. Tomorrow. The bills. The call you didn't return. That little click is a good place to do one thing differently.

Walt, our retired usher, told me he used to switch off the lamp and lie stiff as a board, fists buried in the blanket. His wife said, "Walt, open your hands." He did. He said it was the first time in weeks he felt the mattress under him.

Your hands are the quickest way to tell your body the day is over.

*Our Lady, I'm lying down now. My hands have been fists all day, and here they are, open. Take the tight places in my shoulders and my jaw. Take the list I keep reading to myself. I'll leave the lamp on one more minute and give that minute to you. When the light goes out, stay in the dark with me. Amen.*



TODAY

Sit on the edge of the bed and rest both hands palm-up on your lap for one full minute. Then turn off the light.

☐ DONE

*Where in my body am I holding on hardest tonight?*

PSALM

3 — "I laid myself down and slept"; one honest line a worried sleeper can borrow. (Changed from 12.)




DAY 65

# Three O'Clock Thoughts

*My help comes from the LORD, who made heaven and earth. He will not allow your foot to be moved. He who keeps you will not slumber.*

PSALM 121:2–3 (WEB)

At three o'clock every thought sounds like a verdict. The mistake from years ago. The test result you're waiting on. The silence from your daughter. In that hour a thought talks in a big voice, and it never says "maybe."

I've lain awake making speeches to people who were sound asleep. I won every argument. I was worn out by breakfast.

A thought on paper gets small. It has to fit on the line. In the morning you can look at it in daylight and see what it really was.

*Lord, it's the hour when everything sounds loud. I don't have to answer every thought that knocks. You keep watch, so I can put my head down. Hold the ones I love, and the ones I can't stop worrying about. When a thought comes tonight, show me it's only a thought. I'll write it down and leave it with you. Amen.*



TODAY

Put a pad and pen on your nightstand. If a three o'clock thought comes, write it in one line, whisper "Not now," and lie back down.

☐ DONE

*Which thought comes most often at three, and is it even true?*

PSALM

121 — "he who keeps you will not slumber"; the psalm for the three o'clock hour.

66

DAY 66

# The Phone That Doesn't Ring

*Turn to me, and have mercy on me, for I am desolate and afflicted.*

PSALM 25:16 (WEB)

You keep it close. On the arm of the chair, on the kitchen counter, face up. You tell yourself you're not waiting for it. But you look every time you pass.

A phone that stays quiet isn't a verdict on you. People get busy. People are afraid of saying the wrong thing. Some of them are sitting in a house of their own, looking at the same kind of phone on the same kind of counter.

So don't wait to be found. Reach first, in the smallest way. It costs thirty seconds and a little pride, and pride is poor company at night.

*Mary, you know which name I hope to see on that screen. You know how the quiet sounds in this kitchen. I'm tired of waiting to be remembered. Give me the nerve to reach first. Soften the heart on the other end, and soften mine. Let a little warmth cross the line today, whoever carries it, and let me not mind who it is. Amen.*



TODAY

Call someone and leave a voicemail, even a short one: "I was thinking of you." Say nothing more. Hang up.

☐ DONE

*Who might be hoping I'll be the one to call?*

PSALM

25 — "turn to me, and have mercy on me, for I am desolate"; honest words for a quiet phone. (Changed from 13.)

67

DAY 67

# A Quiet Chair

*“Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations. I will be exalted on the earth.”*

PSALM 46:10 (WEB)

Every house has one chair where nobody argues. The one by the window, or the one with the worn spot on the left arm. It's yours, even if you've never said so.

Most of us only sit there to do something else. Read, knit, watch the news. Today, sit in it to do nothing at all. That's not laziness. In a house this noisy, it may be the bravest thing you do all week.

The first minute, you'll want to get up. Stay. By the third, something in you starts to settle, the way mud settles in a glass of water left alone.

*Father, I'm sitting down. I haven't come to ask for anything yet. I've just come to be quiet with you. The dishes can wait, and so can the phone. Let this chair be the one place where I stop pushing. Let your peace find me here, in these old bones. I'm listening. Quiet me. Amen.*



TODAY

Sit in your favorite chair, with no book and no screen, until the clock has moved five full minutes.

☐ DONE

*What did I hear in the house that I usually talk over?*

PSALM

46 — "be still, and know that I am God"; the stillness psalm for a quiet chair. (Changed from 22.)

68

DAY 68

# The Fear With No Name

*Even though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil, for you are with me. Your rod and your staff, they comfort me.*

PSALM 23:4 (WEB)

Some fears have names. The test. The rent. The son who hasn't called. This one doesn't. It sits on your chest like a cat that won't move, and when you ask what it wants, it says nothing.

I'll tell you plainly, I've felt it. In a cold kitchen, over a cup of tea I forgot to drink. A fear with no name always seems bigger than one with a name. The dark does that. It makes everything bigger.

So we don't fight it today. We give it three words, just enough to hold it up to the light and see its real size.

*Lord Jesus, there's a fear in this house and I can't say what it is. You can. You walked into rooms where people were afraid, and you stood in the middle. Stand in the middle of mine. Mary, put your hand where the weight is. Loosen its grip a little today, just enough to breathe. Amen.*



TODAY

Write three words for how this fear feels, like "heavy, cold, near." Then cross out the heaviest one.

☐ DONE

*If this fear could talk, what would it say it wants?*

PSALM

23 — "I will fear no evil, for you are with me"; the walk through the dark valley.



WEEK 2

# Mary keeps watch

DAYS 69 TO 75

*Tea, goodnight, worry, the radio off, a window, and rest as prayer.*

69

DAY 69

# Mary Keeps Watch

*Wait for the LORD. Be strong, and let your heart take courage. Yes, wait for the LORD.*

PSALM 27:14 (WEB)

Picture a mother standing in a doorway at night, watching a child breathe. She isn't fixing the roof. She isn't paying the bill. She's just there, and the child sleeps better for it.

That doorway is where Mary stands for you. Not with a lecture. Not with a list of what you should have done. She stands with one hand on the frame, and she watches.

You can rest because someone else is awake. You were never going to guard the whole house by yourself. Let her take the first watch tonight. Lie down knowing the doorway is covered.

*Holy Mother, I'm giving you the night watch. I'm tired of keeping guard, and I was never good at it. Stand in the doorway of my room. Watch over this house, the locks and the windows, and the people I love who are far from it. If I wake, let me find you there. I'll sleep, because you're awake. Amen.*



TODAY

Look at a photograph of someone you worry about. Say today's prayer over it once more, slowly, with your hand flat beside the frame.

☐ DONE

*What am I still guarding that I could hand over tonight?*

PSALM

27 — "wait for the LORD; be strong"; a patient psalm for the one who keeps watch.




DAY 70

# Tea and a Psalm



*The LORD is my strength and my shield. My heart has trusted in him, and I am helped. Therefore my heart greatly rejoices. With my song I will thank him.*

PSALM 28:7 (WEB)

Mrs. Doyle has cleaned our church for twenty years. She once told me her whole prayer life is a cup of tea. She puts the kettle on at dusk, sets out two cups, and reads one psalm while it steeps. "The second cup is for whoever God sends," she says. Most nights, nobody comes. She says she isn't lonely.

I used to smile at that. Now I think she's the wisest person in the building.

The cup warms your hands. The psalm warms the rest. Together they tell the evening it's allowed to end.

*Lord, I'm putting the kettle on. Let the steam rise like a quiet prayer. Let the first sip be a thank-you and the last one a rest. If I'm lonely tonight, be the second cup at my table. Mary, sit with me a while. I don't need many words. Warm my hands, and warm the room. Amen.*



TODAY

This evening, set out one extra cup beside yours, even if no one comes. Read one psalm while the tea steeps.

☐ DONE

*Whose company do I miss most at the end of the day?*

PSALM

28 — "the LORD is my strength and my shield"; an evening psalm to read over a warm cup.

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

A quiet evening isn't kept by wanting it. The same tide that tied the knot is still out there, rising a little every night. Fill the kettle tonight, and again tomorrow.




DAY 71

# The House Is Not Empty



*For where two or three are gathered together in my name, there I am in the middle of them.*

MATTHEW 18:20 (WEB)

Walk through the rooms at night and you hear it. The refrigerator hums. A board creaks. Nobody answers when you say "Well." It feels like an empty house.

But it's quiet because certain people are far away, or gone. That isn't the same as empty. Jesus said where two or three are gathered, he is in the middle of them. He never said how many chairs had to be filled.

And the ones you love are here in another way. Every name you carry is a guest in your house tonight. Say it, and they come in.

*Lord Jesus, you promised to be in the middle of us. Be in the middle of this kitchen tonight. Mary, bring in the ones I miss, the living and the gone. Let my children and grandchildren feel a warm hand on their shoulders, wherever they are. Fill this house with your quiet. Stay till I fall asleep. Amen.*



TODAY

Say the names of your family out loud, oldest to youngest, slowly, as if you were seating them at your table.

☐ DONE

*Whose name did I say last, and what did it hold?*

PSALM

139 — "you know me when I sit and when I rise"; the psalm for a house that is never truly empty. (Changed from 29.)




DAY 72

# Say Goodnight Out Loud



*I sought the LORD, and he answered me, and delivered me from all my fears.*

PSALM 34:4 (WEB)

When the children lived here, goodnight was a parade. Down the hall, door by door, a kiss, a blanket, a "sleep tight." Now you click off the television and shuffle to bed without a word. Nobody has said goodnight to you in a long while.

So say it yourself. It'll feel foolish at first. Say it anyway. A house that hears a kind word at the end of the day settles, like a dog that's been patted.

I say goodnight to my kitchen every evening. In all these years it has never once complained.

*Lord, the day is done and I'm still standing in the kitchen. Goodnight to this room, and the chair, and the table that held my elbows. Thank you for the roof, the walls, and the quiet. Mary, walk the halls tonight. Say goodnight to the ones I can't reach, wherever they are. I'm at peace with the dark. Amen.*



TODAY

Tonight, before bed, say "Goodnight" out loud to your kitchen, your chair, and your front door. Then bless the house with the Sign of the Cross.

☐ DONE

*Who used to say goodnight to me, and how did it feel?*

PSALM

34 — "he answered me, and delivered me from all my fears"; a psalm to say as the day closes.




DAY 73

# What Worry Is For



*Why are you in despair, my soul? Why are you disturbed within me? Hope in God! For I shall still praise him for the saving help of his presence.*

PSALM 42:5 (WEB)

Worry thinks it's helping. It believes that if it stays up late enough, it'll find the answer. It never has. Not once in all your years has worry paid a bill, mended a quarrel, or brought a child home.

I won't scold it. Worry is only love with nowhere to go. You worry about them because you love them. The trouble is that love, sitting in the dark with no job, gets tangled.

So give it a job. Write the worry on a scrap of paper, and tuck it between two pages of your Bible, where it's guarded.

*Lord, my worry means well. It's love that lost its way. I'm giving it to you, along with the paper it's written on. Take the worry and keep the love. Mary, hold it in those pages where I can't fidget with it. When I reach for it again tonight, remind me it's already been handed over. Amen.*



TODAY

Write one worry on a scrap of paper. Slip it between two pages of your Bible and leave it there for a week.

☐ DONE

*What is this worry really asking me to love?*

PSALM

42 — "why are you in despair, my soul?"; a psalm that talks back to your own worry.

74

DAY 74

# The Radio Off

*After the earthquake a fire passed; but the LORD was not in the fire. After the fire, there was a still small voice.*

1 KINGS 19:12 (WEB)

For years I fell asleep with the radio on. The voices kept me company. Then I noticed that even asleep I was listening, to the weather and the news. My heart was bracing for the next bad thing.

Elijah went looking for God in the earthquake and the fire. God wasn't in either one. He was in the still small voice that came after.

So turn the radio off for one night. The quiet will feel odd, like a missing tooth you keep touching with your tongue. By the third night it starts to feel like a room that finally belongs to you.

*Father, I've filled this house with voices so I wouldn't hear the quiet. Tonight I'm turning them off. Speak, if you want to, in the stillness. And if you say nothing, let your silence be a blanket. Mary, stay with me in the quiet room. Teach my ears to rest, and my heart to listen without fear. Amen.*



TODAY

Turn off the radio or television, and put a holy picture or crucifix where the dial or screen glow used to be.

☐ DONE

*What am I afraid I'll hear when the house goes quiet?*

PSALM

46 — "be still"; a psalm for a house that has finally gone quiet. (Changed from 43.)




DAY 75

# A Window Open

*But I will sing of your strength. Yes, I will sing aloud of your loving kindness in the morning. For you have been my high tower, a refuge in the day of my distress.*

PSALM 59:16 (WEB)

Marguerite sings in our choir, and she sits up at night with her husband. She told me she opens the bedroom window a hand's width, even in the cold. "The street reminds me the world is still running," she said. "And God runs it better than I do."

I thought about that for days. We close ourselves in to feel safe, and sometimes we only shut ourselves in with the worry.

A little air changes a room. It lets the day's breath out and the night's breath in. Let one open window be your small act of trust.

*Lord, I'm opening a window in this house, and in myself. Let out what's gone stale. Let in the cool air and the far-off sounds of a world you hold. Mary, stand here with me. I don't need to see anything out there. I only need to know it's all in your keeping. Let me breathe. Amen.*



TODAY

Open a window for one minute. Stand beside it, lift your arms, lower them slowly, and thank God for your arms.

☐ DONE

*What have I been keeping shut that needs a little air?*

PSALM

5 — "in the morning I will lay my requests before you"; the psalm for the first light through a window. (Changed from 44.)



WEEK 3

# The lonely hours

DAYS 76 TO 82

*The neighbor, counted blessings, the turned clock, one breath, the big bed, tomorrow.*




DAY 76

# Rest Is a Prayer

*It is vain for you to rise up early, to stay up late, eating the bread of toil, for he gives sleep to his loved ones.*

PSALM 127:2 (WEB)

Some of us have been working since we were fourteen. We don't know how to stop. When we sit down, we feel guilty. When we lie down in the afternoon, we call it weakness.

Look at the verse. God gives sleep to the ones he loves. Rest isn't what you do when the work is done. It's what he hands you while the work is still undone, so you remember it was never all yours.

Lying down with your shoes off and your eyes closed can be a prayer without a single word in it.

*Lord, I've been up early and up late, and the work still isn't finished. Today I lay it down for a few minutes. Let this rest be my prayer. Mary, if I fall asleep, take the prayer from my hands and carry it. Let me wake lighter than I lay down. Teach me I'm loved even while I do nothing. Amen.*



TODAY

Lie down in daylight, shoes off, for five minutes. Eyes closed, hands open. Call it a prayer, and let it be one.

☐ DONE

*What would happen if I rested before the work was done?*

PSALM

127 — "he gives sleep to his loved ones"; the psalm that makes rest a gift, not a failing. (Changed from 46.)




DAY 77

# The Neighbor Down the Hall



*Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ.*

GALATIANS 6:2 (WEB)

Tom lives next door to me, alone, and he's past eighty. Years ago I noticed his newspaper sat on the step until noon. I knocked. He was fine. He'd only been sitting at his table, not wanting to go out and be one more man nobody waved to. We had coffee. He's waved to me every day since.

Somebody near you is Tom. The door across the hall. The house with the same lamp lit every night.

You're not only the one who needs company. You can be the company. That loosens a knot, too.

*Mary, you went over the hills in haste to a neighbor in need. Give me a little of that haste. Show me who's near me and quiet. Let me knock gently, speak plainly, and not mind feeling awkward. Use my small hello. Let my loneliness become a doorway, not a wall. Keep it small and kind. Amen.*



TODAY

Step out into the hallway or onto your front step and greet the first person you see, by name if you know it. Add "How are you today?"

☐ DONE

*Who near me has gone quiet lately, and what would a hello cost?*

PSALM

68 — "God sets the lonely in families"; the psalm of a God who builds a household from strangers. (Verse changed to Galatians 6:2.)

### DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

You're not the only one who can loosen this knot, and you're not the only one it can bind. Somebody on your Names Page, or down the hall, is counting on a hello today. Don't leave them waiting.

78

DAY 78

# Count Blessings, Not Hours

*Praise the LORD, my soul, and don't forget all his benefits,*

PSALM 103:2 (WEB)

At three in the morning you count hours. Two hours until the alarm. One hour since you last looked. Four hours of sleep, and the day is a lost cause. The arithmetic makes you more awake.

Try a different sum. Count what you were given yesterday. The sun on the porch step. The soup that tasted right. The grandson who texted a thumbs-up.

A mind can't count blessings and dread at the same time. Try it. And write them down: a thing on paper holds still, and a worry in the dark never does. Even the crossword you finished counts, and so does the cup of coffee that stayed hot.

*Father, I've been counting the wrong things. Hours, losses, what's still undone. Teach me a new kind of counting. Let me see what was already in my hands yesterday, the small mercies I walked right past. Mary, point them out to me. Make my thanks louder than my worry tonight, even if only by a little. I'll start with the soup. Amen.*



TODAY

Write today's date and three small good things from yesterday. Leave the paper where you'll see it before bed, and read it aloud once.

☐ DONE

*Which small blessing did I almost miss yesterday morning?*

PSALM

103 — "don't forget all his benefits"; the psalm for counting what you were given. (Changed from 54.)

79

DAY 79

# The Clock Turned Around

*You count my wanderings. You put my tears into your container. Aren't they in your book?*

PSALM 56:8 (WEB)

There's a clock by your bed that gives you the worst news in the house. 2:47. 3:12. 3:58. It never says anything kind. It only counts what you've lost.

You're allowed to turn it around. Face it to the wall, like a child sent to the corner. It doesn't have to be the last thing you see before sleep, or the first thing you see when you wake scared.

God keeps the count that matters. Every tear, every wakeful hour, he has written down. Nothing you live through tonight is wasted. Let him do the counting.

*Lord, you keep my tears in your container, and every sleepless hour in your book. Then I don't have to keep the count. I'm turning the clock to the wall. I'm leaving the time to you. Mary, sit with me in the hours I can't name. When morning comes, let me meet it without having watched it arrive. Amen.*



TODAY

Turn the clock by your bed so its face points to the wall. If it's your phone, set it face down across the room.

☐ DONE

*What would I feel if I didn't know what time it was?*

PSALM

56 — "you put my tears into your container"; the psalm that says no tear is wasted.




DAY 80

# Holy Boredom



*My soul, wait in silence for God alone, for my expectation is from him.*

PSALM 62:5 (WEB)

We're afraid of being bored. We fill every gap with the phone, the television, a show we didn't even like. But the oldest prayers started in the gaps. The shepherd waiting with his sheep. The woman at the well at noon. Nothing to do, and God spoke into the nothing.

You can offer God your boredom. It's an honest gift, and not as small as it looks.

Don't try to be holy. Sit with your hands in your lap and let your mind wander the old rooms of the house. See who turns up. Often it's someone you needed to think about.

*Lord, I have nothing to do. Take that as my prayer. I won't fill this quiet with noise. Let the stillness have its say. Mary, keep me company in the long minutes. If memories come, let them be gentle. If nothing comes, let that be enough. I've got nothing to prove. I'm here. You're here. Stay a while. Amen.*



TODAY

Put your phone in another room. Sit at the table for five minutes with nothing to read, watch, or do.

☐ DONE

*What came to mind when I had nothing to fill the quiet?*

PSALM

62 — "my soul, wait in silence for God alone"; the psalm for an empty hour offered to God. (Changed from 57.)




DAY 81

# One Breath, One Word

*I wait for the LORD. My soul waits. I hope in his word. My soul longs for the Lord more than watchmen long for the morning, more than watchmen for the morning.*

PSALM 130:5–6 (WEB)

When the mind spins, long prayers are too heavy to lift. You've got no strength for paragraphs. So go small. One breath, one word.

Breathe in and say "Mary" in your heart. Breathe out and say "Jesus." That's the whole prayer. People have prayed it in prison cells and hospital rooms and in kitchens at four in the morning.

The watchmen on the wall had one job: stay awake until dawn. You don't even have to do that tonight. One breath, one word, and let the night keep its own watch.

*Jesus, Mary. In and out. I have no more words tonight, and I don't need any. You know what's in me before I say it. Hold the breath going in, and hold the breath going out. Let this small prayer be a rope I can pull on in the dark. Stay until it's light. Amen.*



TODAY

Put a hand on your heart. Breathe in for four counts, out for six, three times. In: "Mary." Out: "Jesus."

☐ DONE

*What would my day be like if I prayed only one word?*

PSALM

130 — "my soul longs for the Lord more than watchmen for the morning"; the psalm for a prayer that is only a breath. (Changed from 59.)




DAY 82

# When the Bed Feels Too Big

*For you have been my help. I will rejoice in the shadow of your wings. My soul stays close to you. Your right hand holds me up.*

PSALM 63:7–8 (WEB)

Eileen, a widow from Scranton, told me the hardest part wasn't the funeral. It was the first night after, when she slept on her own side out of habit, and the other side stayed cool and flat. "It's like a field," she said. "I don't know how to cross it."

If you know that field, I won't tell you it shrinks fast. But I'll tell you what Eileen did. Each night she said her husband's name, softly, into the dark. Not to hear him answer. Only to say he'd been here.

Love is allowed to keep talking.

*Lord, this bed is too big and the room is too quiet. I miss the weight beside me, and the small sounds of someone breathing. Mary, lie close to my sorrow. Carry my love across the field to the one I miss, and carry theirs back to me. Let me sleep on my side and not be alone in it. Amen.*



TODAY

Say softly, "I'm tired, and I'm still here." Then say the name of the one who used to sleep beside you.

☐ DONE

*What do I most want the one I miss to know tonight?*

PSALM

63 — "your right hand holds me up"; the psalm for a bed that has too much room in it. (Changed from 62.)



WEEK 4

# Letters, pillow prayers, rain, a lullaby, and dawn

DAYS 83 TO 91

*The month ends with the quiet candle.*




DAY 83

# Evening Light

*The light shines in the darkness, and the darkness hasn't overcome it.*

JOHN 1:5 (WEB)

A candle doesn't fight the dark. It doesn't argue or push the dark out of the room. It stands in it and glows, and the dark has nothing to say back.

Prayer works that way too. You can't wrestle the night until it surrenders. But one small light turns it into a room where someone is home.

The flame is small. That's the point. Hold your palm near it and feel the warmth before you look at the light. Warmth is the part you can carry to bed. God has never needed much light to find a person sitting in the dark.

*Mary, here's my small light. It won't scare the night away, and I'm not asking it to. I only ask that it keep me company. Let it be a sign that someone is awake in this house, and that someone is you. Hold my eyes on the flame and my heart where it can rest. Amen.*



TODAY

This evening, light a candle. Hold one palm near it, then count ten slow breaths while you watch the flame. Blow it out gently and say "Amen."

☐ DONE

*What small light in my life have I been overlooking?*

PSALM

119 — "your word is a lamp to my feet"; the lamp psalm for a small light in a dark room. (Changed from 63.)

84

DAY 84

# Tomorrow Can Wait

*Your bars will be iron and bronze. As your days, so your strength will be.*

DEUTERONOMY 33:25 (WEB)

Tomorrow has a way of arriving in the middle of tonight. It walks right in and unpacks. The appointment. The bill. The family dinner nobody wants to host. By midnight you've lived it six times, and it hasn't happened yet.

The old blessing says, "As your days, so your strength will be." Strength comes in daily portions, cut to the size of the day. You can't borrow from tomorrow's.

Tomorrow's strength shows up tomorrow. Tonight you only need enough to lie down. Say to the day ahead: "I'll meet you when you get here."

*Lord, I've been living tomorrow in advance. Tonight I want to live only tonight. Take the appointment, the bill, and the visit I dread, and keep them till morning. Mary, give me tonight's bread, and only that. When tomorrow comes, I'll ask for tomorrow's. For now, let me close my eyes. Keep me steady. Amen.*



TODAY

Pick one thing you won't worry about until nine tomorrow morning. Say it aloud: "That belongs to tomorrow."

☐ DONE

*What have I rehearsed that may never happen?*

PSALM

31 — "my times are in your hand"; the psalm that hands over every tomorrow. (Verse is Deuteronomy 33:25; psalm changed from 64.)

DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

Today's peace is today's bread. It won't cover tomorrow, and it doesn't keep in a drawer. Come back to the page in the morning. The knot you loosened tonight can pull tight again by dawn.




DAY 85

# A Letter You Don't Send

*Cast your burden on the LORD and he will sustain you. He will never allow the righteous to be moved.*

PSALM 55:22 (WEB)

There's a letter you've been writing in your head for years. You know the first line. You know exactly what you'd say. To the one who hurt you, or the one you hurt, or the one who left too soon.

Write it down tonight, and don't send it. The letter isn't for them. It's for the weight in your chest, which has never had a chance to speak.

Say all of it. Be unfair. Be loud on paper. God isn't shocked by anything you can write, and the paper won't take offense.

*Father, there are words I've carried too long. I'm putting them on paper tonight, and I'm putting them in your hands. Take what's true in them and what's only pain. Mary, you know what it is to hold a sorrow without speaking. Give me the courage to say it here, where it's safe. Then let me sleep. Amen.*



TODAY

Write a two-line note to someone, put it in an envelope, and seal it. Don't mail it. Decide tomorrow what to do with it.

☐ DONE

*What do I most need to say that no one has heard?*

PSALM

55 — "cast your burden on the LORD"; the psalm for what you cannot say to anyone's face. (Changed from 68.)




DAY 86

# Pillow Prayers



*The day is yours, the night is also yours. You have prepared the light and the sun.*

PSALM 74:16 (WEB)

When the lamp is off and the sheets are cool, your mind turns to the people you love. That's a good habit. It only needs a shape.

Most of us pray for everyone in one breath. "Bless them all." But each of them has a face. Give each name its own moment, even three seconds, with the face that goes with it. A name said slowly is a small candle held up to heaven.

The night belongs to God, the verse says, and so does the day. You can hand him the people and be done. That's all a pillow prayer asks.

*Lord, the night is yours, and so are the people I love. I'm laying them on this pillow, one at a time. Keep them. Mary, put a hand on each head. Whoever is awake tonight, give them company. Whoever is asleep, give them rest. And when I run out of names, let me sleep with them in your hands. Amen.*



TODAY

Read three names from your Names Page aloud. After each, say one sentence of prayer, like "Mary, please keep her."

☐ DONE

*Which name is hardest for me to say out loud?*

PSALM

74 — "the day is yours, the night is also yours"; the psalm that hands the night to God.




DAY 87

# The Sound of Rain

*He will come down like rain on the mown grass, as showers that water the earth.*

PSALM 72:6 (WEB)

Walt told me that as a young man he used to open the porch door when it rained and just stand there. Not to get wet. Only to listen. "It's the only thing in the world that talks without asking for anything," he said.

Rain falls on every roof without choosing. The careful and the careless, the grieving and the glad. If it rains tonight, let it remind you that you're inside a story God is still writing.

And if it doesn't rain, listen to the quiet. It has its own kind of falling. I like to think of the roof doing its job while I do none.

*Lord, I hear the rain on the roof, or I imagine it. Either way, thank you for the sound of a world that goes on without my help. Mary, let the rain wash the dust off my thoughts. Make me soft ground, ready to receive. Let tonight's water feed whatever you're growing in me. Amen.*



TODAY

Sit by a window and listen to the rain, or to the hum of the house, for three minutes. Say nothing. Just hear.

☐ DONE

*What is growing in me that needs this quiet?*

PSALM

72 — "like showers that water the earth"; the psalm for a night of rain. (Changed from 77.)

88

DAY 88

# What the Night Taught You

*I will bless the LORD, who has given me counsel. Yes, my heart instructs me in the night seasons.*

PSALM 16:7 (WEB)

Look back over these weeks. You've had long nights, and some were bad. But I wonder what you learned in them.

Maybe you learned you can survive an hour of fear. Maybe you learned the sound of your own breathing, or exactly where the streetlight lands on the ceiling. Maybe you found out that the one you worry about is awake somewhere too, and you're connected across the dark.

The night is a hard teacher. It doesn't smile. But what it teaches stays, like the best lessons do. Write yours down before they fade, in plain words.

*Lord, thank you for what the dark taught me. I didn't ask for it, and I wouldn't choose it again. But I see now you were teaching me in the night. Mary, help me keep what's true and forget what was only fear. Let what I learned in the dark become a lamp I carry into the day. Amen.*



TODAY

Write one sentence that begins, "A sleepless night taught me..." Leave it on your nightstand where you'll see it tonight.

☐ DONE

*What did the night teach me that the day never could?*

PSALM

16 — "my heart instructs me in the night seasons"; the psalm that finds a teacher in the dark. (Changed from 83.)

89

DAY 89

# Lullaby for a Grown Child

*The LORD is your keeper. The LORD is your shade on your right hand. The sun will not harm you by day, nor the moon by night.*

PSALM 121:5-6 (WEB)

Patricia and Dale told me they still sing to their son. He's forty-one and lives far away. He doesn't know. At night, in their kitchen, they say a blessing together and picture him standing at a sink of his own.

You can do the same. A mother doesn't stop being a mother when the child grows up. He can be a hundred miles off, or silent on the phone, and the lullaby still reaches him. The words don't need his ears.

Say the old words over a photograph. Slowly, like rocking.

*Lord, bless my child, who isn't a child anymore, and keep him. Make your face shine on him. Be gracious to him in the rooms I can't see. Mary, rock him tonight in your mantle, the way I once rocked him in these arms. Give him peace, and give me peace about him. Let this lullaby reach where I can't. Amen.*



TODAY

Hold a photograph of your child or grandchild. Say the words of the verse over them slowly, the way you once sang them to sleep.

☐ DONE

*What did I used to sing or say to them at bedtime?*

PSALM

67 — "may God be gracious to us and bless us"; the family blessing psalm. (Changed from 89.)




DAY 90

# Your Best Hour Is Coming



*Arise, shine; for your light has come, and the LORD's glory has risen on you!*

ISAIAH 60:1 (WEB)

Here's a promise from someone who has walked a lot of nights. Dawn always comes. It might be gray and slow, and it might not fix one thing on your list. But it comes, and in it the dark loses its voice.

The verse says your light has come. It doesn't say someday. It has come, and you may be too tired to notice it at first. Light doesn't knock. It just gets into the room.

So tonight, when it's longest, leave the curtain open a hand's width. The first gray light will find you on its own.

*Lord, the night's been long, and I'm nearly at the end of it. I trust the morning is already on its way. Mary, stay with me until first light. Let it find me rested, or at least at peace with being tired. Let this house be ready to receive it, dishes and all. Open the day, and open me. Amen.*



TODAY

Stand beside your bed and make the Sign of the Cross slowly over it, as if blessing the night you've just had. Then open the curtain.

☐ DONE

*What will I do with my first quiet minute of daylight?*

PSALM

30 — "weeping may stay for the night, but joy comes in the morning"; the psalm that promises dawn. (Changed from 88.)




DAY 91

# The Quiet Candle

*He who dwells in the secret place of the Most High will rest in the shadow of the Almighty.*

PSALM 91:1 (WEB)

Ninety mornings. Think about that. You opened this book the first morning after the nine nights, and here you are, ninety mornings later. You're still here. So is she.

Look around the house. It's the same house. The same cups, the same chair, the same window. But there's something in the air that wasn't there before. A little less braced. A little more resting. That's the quiet we've been practicing.

Tonight, light the last candle of the month. Let it say, without words, that this is a house where someone prays.

*Mother Mary, thank you for the quiet. It isn't perfect, and some nights it's thin. But it's more than I had. Keep this house the way you keep a sleeping child. Keep the ones in it, and the ones far away. Let the candle burn in me when the real one is out. Let the quiet stay. Amen.*



TODAY

Light a candle and say the name of the month out loud: "The Quiet House." Let it burn while you eat breakfast, and blow it out with "Amen."

☐ DONE

*What is the quietest place in my house now, and who sits there?*

PSALM

91 — "he who dwells in the secret place of the Most High will rest"; the psalm that closes the month in rest.

### DON'T LET IT TIE AGAIN

I let it slip once. I put the candle in a drawer and went back to my old nights. The house got loud again, quickly. Light it tomorrow, and the day after. That's all I ask.

# CLOSING OF BOOK 3 · THE QUIET HOUSE

## LOOKING BACK

Four questions. Take your time. Tick the box when you have answered.

[ ] What did I learn about the hour when I wake?

[ ] Which night was the hardest, and what carried me through it?

[ ] Who did I reach out to this month, or who reached out to me?

[ ] Where in the house do I feel quieter than a month ago?

## A LETTER FROM FATHER LUCAS

You have walked thirty mornings with me, and some of them were hard. I'm proud of you, and I don't say that lightly. You lit lamps. You called people back. You sat in a chair and did nothing, which is harder than it sounds.

The house isn't silent yet. It may never be. But listen: it isn't braced anymore. You have taught it that the dark has company.

Now keep it. A quiet house isn't built once. It's swept every day, the way a porch is. If a knot starts to tighten again, don't be ashamed. Come back to the page. It will be waiting, and so will she.

Turn to Book 4 tomorrow.

— Father Lucas

### THE SEAL OF THE MONTH

**THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS · BOOK 3 · THE QUIET HOUSE**

Date:

### THE CANDLE OF THE MONTH: THE QUIET HOUSE

Light the candle. Say the names on your Names Page, slowly, one by one.

Let the flame burn while you sit in your chair. Then blow it out with an "Amen."



THIS CERTIFIES THAT

NAME

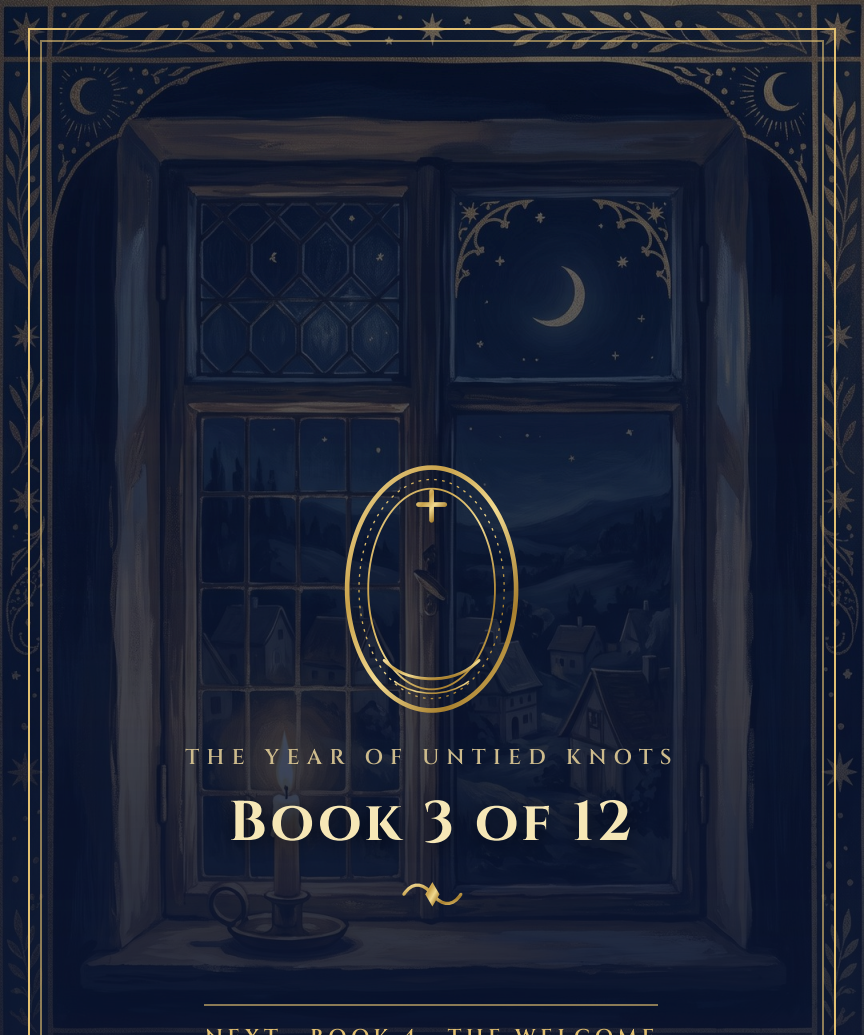
# Ninety Mornings

*Ninety mornings kept. The house is quieter than when you began.*

*Father Lucas*

DATE

AUGSBURG



THE YEAR OF UNTIED KNOTS

# Book 3 of 12

NEXT · BOOK 4 · THE WELCOME